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Subverting the Patriarchal Trope by Challenging Toxic Masculinity in Feminist Revenge Fantasy: An Analysis of Anvita Dutt's 'Bulbul' and Prosit Roy's 'Pari'

_____Quincy Tikadar

Abstract

Women have always faced the patriarchal principles of society; her life is designed by the stereotypical doctrines making it hugely constructed. The aim of my paper is to explore how the body of the woman acts as her radical tool to fight against the authority in the movie Bulbul (2020) by Anvita Dutt and the movie Pari (2018) by Prosit Roy. This present paper mainly delves into the way both 'Pari' and 'Bulbul' portrays how 'superstition' is entwined with women's lives and how they are taking the agency of 'darkness' to avenge their tormentors, by setting an example of 'unconventional women'. Based on discussions of certain literary theories both of them project how supernatural elements are used as a symbol to objectify major social issues. This particular paper mainly aims at breaking down the gendered notion correlated with black magic. As both the protagonists of the stories thrive in a parallel world and challenges the masculinist attitude toward sexism. The irony of the story lies how darkness is related to patriarchy and how men represent evil. My paper discovers how the journey of self-awakening by both women through the extraordinary steps to release her functions as the symbolic delineation of other women. That how in a man's world women are being taken for granted and compromise is appreciated under all circumstances. How 'toxic masculinity' is celebrated and embraced by all cultures in order to domesticate their women and restrict them to their private space. I will further comment on how the 'genre' of horror is defining rage filled female fantasy in films in the South Asian Literary Tradition.

Keywords: Feminism, existentialism, patriarchy, oppression, culture-vulture, sexual violence.

1. Introduction

‘Bulbul’ and ‘Pari’ highlight the pervasive influence of patriarchy on women's identities, positions in society, and autonomy over their bodies. It emphasizes how patriarchal power dynamics dictate societal norms, including attitudes towards women's sexuality and agency. It argues that women are often constrained by societal expectations and norms, leaving little room for them to define their own identities and determine how their bodies and voices should be acknowledged and respected. The act of sexually violating women does not remain confined to the idea of delivering pain to the female body but rather carries the larger idea of vilification and stripping the identity and value system they carry with themselves.

This paper aims to conduct a comparative analysis of the films from a feminist perspective to explore the possibility of women possessing the power or agency to construct and reclaim their own identities, despite the imposition of a superficial female identity by patriarchal forces. This investigation delves into the complex dynamics of gender, power, and identity construction within societal frameworks.

Rukshana resides within a realm of darkness. Both she and her mother are the targets of Aulachakra, a satanic cult which is infamous for breeding Ifrits (demons). She lives separated from the mainstream population and people call her mother ‘kutte wali aurat’ and mentally disturbed. Even the morgue boys view her suspiciously and ask Arnab about her whereabouts and the police trifle her as a disturbed girl. Even Arnab's mom frequently tells him to leave her in her state, and calls her a burden as she may try to create trouble for them later. She enters into Arnab's life, falls for him and considers him her savior. She is elated after conceiving his child and desires to raise a family with him. She couldn't kill him at last and risked her own life to save

him and her daughter as a result of her unconditional love. She was the 'other woman' who couldn't 'fit in' into the human world which is harsh, has no room for emotion and will eliminate 'others' who reside beyond terrestrial boundaries, and are non-humans. For the first time in her life, she finds someone so hospitable and trustworthy unlike Professor Qasim Ali, who ransacked their lives. She feels that she has certain rights on him and couldn't stand by any other woman who's going to snatch him from her. She is quite jealous when Piyali kisses Arnab, and tries to kill her after escaping from the bondage, as Arnab left her to be killed in order to marry Piyali. Her blind love allowed him to chain her, as little did she know that he would betray him and would be no different from the men involved in Aulachakra. Her killing of the Professor was successful as the verses of Quran which was recited by him could not obstruct her as she was wearing earphones which she previously used to listen to music. Piyali's change of mind after she tried to kill Rukshana to save herself is due to the fact that she couldn't save her unborn child and had to abort it, and could not kill another child and thus helped in her delivery. Both of them were deserted by their men during times when they needed them the most, Rukshana by Arnab and Piyali by her boyfriend, thus sharing commonness in grief and betrayal. (Sen 2018)

2. Defying institutionalized oppression

Women often internalized patriarchy and oppression. It's evident in *Bulbbul* where in one of the scenes, Binodini washes the blood off Bulbbul's thigh and convinces her to keep this rape incident a secret as she belongs to a Royal family. Binodini States: He's a little...insane, but he'll be fine after marriage. He's a little insane, but...he's of royal blood. Keep quiet. He's a little insane, but you will be adorned in jewels. He's a little insane, but...you will be draped in silks. You will get respect. Keep quiet." This dialogue presents how some women are guilty of internalizing patriarchy and oppression as they try to silence each other and encourage other

women to act in a way they are supposed to behave. (Singh 2023)

Similarly, in *Pari*, a scene of rape-anxiety torture is introduced, where the professor forces women into bathtubs as they scream while their babies are being aborted while he imposes the smell of incense like cigarette butts in order to calm them down. In this dingy room, lower class men in chains surround this specter where the professor becomes the exorcist of women who are trying to escape the harassment as their bodies become the battleground for both the orders.

Rukshana's story begins as a release. Her mother had detained her in animal-like captivity and her love for Arnab is a celebration of freedom which leans towards a happy childhood—as she adorns herself with paper flowers— something that she never had. Her sexuality is without shame in comparison to Arnab. His residence transforms into her sanctuary, and she embodies an unpredictable guardian with monstrous qualities. (Sen 2018)

3. Deconstructing the ‘male gaze’ by the ‘avenged’ women

In one of the scenes, Rukshana leaps down from the morgue closet to bite the staff which results in his death, as an act of revenge for injuring her lover. Rukshana receives her powers on the basis of moon cycles like a werewolf. The regret in her eyes is evident when her transformation leads her to bite into a street dog's neck.

Rukshana also spoke to how women generally have to pay the price for male pleasure. She is the result of rape, and Qasim Ali insists she must die because she is an abomination. She never chose to be born but she has a life. Without Arnab's protection, despite her inherent power, she has no voice in society. He castigates her as if it was all her fault they had sex. The professor and his band of weirdos don't just want her to die a clean death, they want her to suffer to pay for existing. (Sen 2018)

According to the legends, Chudails are women with uncontrolled sexuality and exist in an alternate world order. In both these movies the disheveled hair of Ifrit and Chudail represents untamed sexuality and their dominant position in the Patriarchal structure where they are uncontrolled and craving for revenge and cannot be domesticated which completely contrasts with Binodini's shaved head denoting her widowhood and submissiveness to patriarchy. She chooses to live secluded in the domestic space occupied by women and remain involved in ritual and worship, thus living an austere life unlike her previous stage where she fulfilled her desires through Indranil. (Mohsin 2020) Her transformation from a hierarchical to a submissive position contrasts with Bulbbul's rising to a superior position from an inferior one. Both Satya and Arnab in these movies could not keep their promise and betrayed these women who were further punished for no fault of theirs by Qasim Ali and his men in *Pari* and Indranil and Mahendra in *Bulbbul*, and further leaving their marks on their bodies so that they will never be able to forget their disturbing past. Even the physically challenged brother-in-law doesn't leave her unharmed but is licensed by patriarchy, firstly, because of his superior position in the household and secondly, of his destitute condition. Both *Bulbbul* and *Rukshana* kill the men who inflicted violence on women, as in *Pari*, Professor Qasim Ali and his men, and in *Bulbbul*, the abusive men in the villages; thus eliminating all sorts of injustices from the society. Both Binodini and *Rukshana* couldn't stand by another woman, here Piyali and *Bulbbul*, as they were othered and couldn't fit in the conjugal space as the familial sphere doesn't accommodate 'the other woman' who is a threat to a happily married life.

4. Women in a "Masculine" Genre

The professor is scarcely different from the villagers who forced the woman to undergo rape and abortion in an unusual situation. The horror of impregnation equates the horror of

barbarous abortions, where children were beheaded. The unborn child is struggling between two orders. But Rukshana stands apart from these extremes as her pregnancy emerges from genuine human connection and love and is deviating from the horrific acts of forced impregnation and violent termination of pregnancy. (Sen 2018) Arnab states in the end of the movie, “Uss bacchi ki nabhi ki dori thi, shayad uski payda hone ke peeche Ruksana ki ma ki nafrat nahin Ruksana ki pyaar thi”.

The movie eventually points at the dynamic of translation into a darker social reality of sex trafficking, which when Arnab takes Rukshana to an orphanage, both of them are shocked as children are flogged and are in a place where no child remains a child for long. The movie connects with another social reality of the forced abortions of these raped women, in order to keep them in circulation and trafficking. The children who are born in such horrid conditions lose their childhood early on and barely have time for fairy tales. “Pari: Not A Fairytale” is thus a suitable title. Which is somewhat same for Bulbbul, the fairy tales which she is narrated during childhood comes back to life as her innocent world is violated by the men in her society who don't allow her to believe in fairytales. The title Bulbbul is thus misspelled, to add some suspense to it. (Mohsin 2020)

Eventually, Arnab relieves himself of all social responsibility and gives Rukshana away to the professor. As a result, Rukshana too dies of her own ‘zeher’ – anger which was initially against a world where she had no refuge. In patriarchal ideology, the image of women can only signify anything in relation to men. The sign “woman” is thus negatively represented as “not-man,” which means that the “woman-as-woman” is absent from the film. (Sen 2018)

5. Categorizing the Institution of Femicide

Both these movies valorise the female reproductive biology which traps Bulbbul and

Rukshana in confined systems of motivation, by showing her adherence to a constrictive societal and gendered norm of motherhood. The nature of womanhood, as explained by feminist philosopher Simone de Beauvoir in her monumental work, *The Second Sex* is defined entirely in relation and opposition to men, so women cannot achieve any real sense of self-fulfillment on their own. This illuminates how women are socialized from a young age to perceive themselves through the lens of the male gaze. (Bhalero 2021)

Bulbbul suffers many instances of gendered violence from a very young age: child marriage, physical abuse, rape. Violence as pedagogic and symbolic is evident in the scene where Indranil pulls Bulbbul's hair from the bathtub and beats her mercilessly resulting in breaking her legs in order to curb her mobility and freedom as she dared to deviate from her 'streedharma' by falling for Satya, her brother in law. His insecurity about their friendship made him injure her in order to make her both physically and emotionally disabled. Though he himself had an illicit relationship with his sister-in-law Binodini. He was followed by his disabled brother who raped her to death. The rape, followed by a brief stillness that looks like she has met death altogether, is a fairytale-esque turning point for her. It seems that the goddess herself has occupied her body to give her supernatural powers from a single decreasing appearance of a Kali idol. The rest of the film unfolds to show that her new powers enable her to build an alternate reputation as a chudail and kill several men from the village surrounding her mansion, all of whom have at least attempted to hurt other women. (Mohsin 2020)

6. Contextualizing the Discourse of the wronged woman

A story built around a woman is deviated with a larger politic concerning womanhood and experiences of gender and sexuality. Bulbbul share a cigarette with doctor Sudip in privacy, far away from the disapproval of patriarchy. Bulbul resorts to a life of empowerment that is

facilitated by the upper-caste, colonial, affluent zamindari life she was married into, all of which are agents of patriarchal oppression. Her new-found 'empowerment' does not challenge her brother-in-law's authority over her nor does it change the larger scheme of things for her village, where she has been the unchallenged authority since her husband's departure. Every time she kills a man, she leaves no hint for villagers to know what wrongdoing he has been punished for, or that he has been punished at all. She resorts to silent castigator punishments which simply cancel men from the larger association of violence. Her sister-in-law Binodini, who is also forced into a marriage, tasked with care-giving, and has little agency or power, is punished by widowhood, another form of patriarchal violence. Both Rukshana and Bulbul dies in the end unable to bear the pain mankind had inflicted on them. Their choice of transgressing their boundaries set by men is a threat to heteronormative familial structure which questions the gendered norms at every step by revealing the dark-sides of Patriarchy in the society. They resort to witchcraft, an un-human way which punishes their perpetrators who onced wronged their bodies, thus taking the agency of the supernatural to fight against the injustices inflicted by the natural world. Their revenge is giving voice to many victims whose voices were suppressed by the Patriarchal constraints and thus giving them a platform to narrate their stories. (Mohsin 2020)

7. Heroine or Victim: the stereotyped gender

In this educational task, I am referring to Paulo Freire's seminal book "Pedagogy of the Oppressed," Paulo Freire highlights dialogue as a crucial aspect of human interaction, stressing its core in spoken language. Considering dialogue as a literary element, it becomes integral to human emotions, sharing the ability to evoke feelings in readers or audiences. The dichotomy of the oppressor and oppressed is highlighted repeatedly as stated by Paulo, the oppressed might get themselves in the role of the oppressor. Bulbul's matriarchal control of the household is an

imitation of patriarchal supremacy. The religious scriptures are further influencing colonization of the psyches of women stated through her character, who is influenced by religion and tradition. Binodini, being a victim of patriarchy, is wedded to a mentally unstable man, is tremendously jealous of Bulbbul's bond with Indranil and tells him of her love-affair towards Satya, thus instilling jealousy in him leading to his breaking her limbs. Religion is used both as a medium for oppression and agency by these women, Bulbbul kills Mahendra during Durgashtami to avenge her rape. Both these women kill their perpetrators to avenge themselves of the injustices meted out to them thus hitting back at patriarchy. Susan Brownmiller argues that “most women confronted by physical aggression fall apart at the seams and suffer a paralysis of will. We have been trained to cry, to wheedle, to plead, to look for a male protector, but we have never been trained to fight and win” (1975:402).

Textual space is basically considered a male realm limiting women intervention; here Bulbbul steps in through storytelling. Satya's fairytales are exemplary and pedagogic but insensibly vilifies women; making them responsible for any crime. Bulbul intervenes into the textual space only to be devoured by the chudail of Satya's tales as the story is entangled after her demise.

Satya even fails to recognize Bulbbul, in the guise of a chudail, as his sexist outlook prevented his conscience from discovering the truth as he always expected women to internalize the pain which has been practiced through centuries.

8. Conclusion

Both these movies valorise toxic masculinity and perpetration of violence on women in order to keep patriarchy intact and enjoy benefits from them. Women are being punished for trying to challenge this concept of identity given by the men in power and subverting their

position of domesticity and subjugation. Thus, through the characterisation of Bulbbul and Rukshana, we witness the lives and perspectives of two different women and their envisage of the world around them and their traversal of the conservative culture from completely different perspectives.; thus giving us an all-inclusive viewpoint of the Female identity as a profoundly developed construct operated by patriarchal forces effectively installing feminine virtues according to their requirements. As a woman's worth is fashioned according to male interests rather than women's choices therefore highlighting the patriarchal framework and their outlook of women's conduct and value and both these heroines successfully transgresses the existing power relations between men and women by unconventionally questioning the status quo and state machinery of its privileged power positions.

The phrase “women as a category of analysis” thus states the crucial assumption that all females, regardless of class or culture, have some kind of social confluence indicated prior to the analysis process as a homogeneous group. Women are considered to be a single category of people based on shared oppression in any given feminist analysis. The sociological notion of the “sameness” of their oppression binds them together. (Mason 2014)

Salah M. Hassan in her seminal essay, ‘Gendered Visions’ demonstrates: “They are no longer the displaced and subdued objects of a hegemonic (foreign or male) gaze; they have instead become centrally located, active creators who call such a gaze in question.”

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